

Creative and Entrepreneurial Statement

Revised · August 2026 · John McSwain · CRCP 6320

I build small engines of learning for the stubborn, for the people who still insist on indulging their curiosity, because a good idea stains, and it doesn't wash out.

My statement survived the semester intact, which genuinely surprises me. What has changed is that I can now point at built things when I say it. In early May, I could describe the work I wanted to do. In August I have four projects that argue for it, and a much clearer sense of which parts of the argument were convictions and which were preferences I had never tested.

What I made

I made some tools that behave like instruments, designed to be small, runnable, opinionated things that can exist in your hands. My work sits at the intersection of learning design, interaction design, and creative technology. In practice, that might mean I write the pedagogy and the code in the same afternoon, and each one keeps the other honest.

This semester, that work manifested into a commitment app built around a single promise, a merged product made with a classmate whose design instincts differed from mine, a browser instrument for voice and rhythm, and finally a record label for micro-lessons as a metaphor for learning discography.

Who it's for

My audience is perpetual “tryers” who have an incomplete reading list, who still have one subject they cannot put down, and no structure left to hold it. They have plenty of motivation, but they lack tools that fit the shape of an adult life, where focus is fragmented, hands are busy, and weeks go missing without warning. My audience is learning on a commute or a walk, and a tool that demands their attention is one they cannot use. The audience settled the format before I had an opinion about it.

What I believe, and what it costs

In Deep Cuts, I tried to write and maintain a shame-free recall mechanic: answer a question wrong and the track folds the answer back into the lesson with no penalty.

How I work

I build the thing to find out whether the idea is any good. Documents describing an experience are cheap and forgiving; the experience itself is neither. Nearly every real decision this semester came from something running badly in front of me: an animation that seemed like an apology, a wait that seemed like a bug, a wrong answer that seemed like a scolding.

When I merged my project with Karen's mid-semester project, the assignment invited a compromise, and a compromise would have produced a product with two half-arguments. Forcing the merger to generate a genuinely new artifact was harder and better. It also stress-tested my no-shame architecture against a design that had not inherited my assumptions, and the architecture held.

What I'm building toward

I want to design and build learning experiences for organizations and individuals who have noticed that their training makes people feel like cattle. That work runs through teaching, workshops, consulting, and the tools themselves.

So the near-term plan is unglamorous and specific: make small engines, publish the workbench alongside the finished object, and keep testing the work on people.

Where this leaves me

I came into the semester able to say what I wanted to make. I am leaving it so it can show why it should exist and prove that it works, which is a smaller-sounding change than it is. The sentence at the top has not moved. What is behind it has: four artifacts, one principle that survived contact with a collaborator and with my own implementation errors, and a much shorter distance between what I say I believe and what my code actually does.

The stain metaphor was always the point. A good idea gets on you. You do not get to choose when it comes out, and the tools worth building are the ones that help it set.